form, even as the Neighbourhood First policy struck roots and the extended neighbourhoods advanced in all directions. The global footprint is widening too, visible as much in Africa and Latin America as in the Pacific and the Caribbean. Multiple engagements simultaneously with major power centres have also intensified, though not always without challenges. The Vaccine Maitri strongly reaffirmed credentials as a champion of the South, just as first responder operations highlighted our international commitment. Operations like Kaveri, Ganga, Devi Shakti and Ajay underline that Indians abroad could count on their government during times of difficulty. And a decade that began with the advocacy of yoga is appropriately seeing the espousal of *Sri Anna* (millets). The journey will continue but this is a time to take stock and assess what difference we have made. And that exercise will surely bring out why we matter more to the world.

At the end of the day, foreign policy is very much about clinically assessing the global landscape and calculating one's prospects. Only if the larger picture is accurately read can the risks and benefits of any course of action be assessed. But no nation plans or acts in a vacuum. It must have a vision for itself, an architecture in mind and objectives to attain. For both practical and cultural reasons, these may not always be spelt out explicitly. But by analysing the world, describing processes and suggesting solutions, their outlines can nevertheless be discerned. To that extent, this is also a volume to be read between the lines.

India's G20 presidency is also instructive in offering insights about how to navigate current world politics. By relentlessly shining the spotlight on the concerns of the Global South, we were able to ensure that the G20 returned to its basic mandate of promoting international growth and development. Defining priorities in that regard and devising collective solutions were also objectives that were attained to considerable measure. Faced with the parallel challenges of East–West polarization and North–South divide, each was utilized to mitigate the other problem. A firm diplomatic posture that included some new practices on interim outcomes encouraged consensus to be reached when it really mattered. Taking the initiative to enable the permanent membership of the African Union (AU) was notable in itself and helpful in strengthening the larger narrative.

A takeaway from the G20 Summit in Delhi was the demonstration that the more ambitious the agenda, the harder it would be for others to play spoilsport. Equally, by nurturing crucial relationships over a period of time,